

European Court of Justice

“The Court of Justice of the European Union, based in Luxembourg, is established.”

The Court of Justice of the European Union (CJEU) is the highest judicial body of the EU. Since 1952, it has ensured the uniform interpretation and application of European law in all member states. It rules on infringements, actions for annulment and requests for preliminary rulings from national courts.

- EU law takes precedence over national law.
- The direct effect enables the direct application of EU regulations without national implementation.
- Harmonisation aims at uniform rules (but meets with national resistance).
- National courts are obliged to take EU law into account in their decisions.
- Deviations from national regulations can create legal uncertainties and conflicts with EU law.

The ECJ began its work as the first European institution to have a control or jurisdictional instrument in the implementation of the ECSC Treaties.

Treaty of Paris

“The European Coal and Steel Community (ECSC), also known as montanunion enters into force.”

The ECSC was the first predecessor of today's European Union. These six "founding states" belonged to the ECSC: Belgium, Germany, France, Italy, Luxembourg and the Netherlands. The aim was to secure peace through economic interdependence (a short path to armoury production is thus made impossible), creating a common market for coal and steel products, dismantling customs duties and preventing the formation of cartels.

The ECSC Treaty expired in 2002 and was taken over into the EU.

French Foreign Minister Robert Schumann initiated the drafting of a plan for future German-French cooperation. Jean Monnet, head of the French planning authority, was mainly responsible. In essence, it envisaged the merger of the coal and steel industries of the two countries, which was to be managed by an administrative authority under the supervision of a joint organisation. At that time, coal and steel were considered guarantors of the economic resurgence of the countries and they were fundamental means of warfare. For France, this plan was ideal for retaining influence on the German coal and steel industry, which would have been lost after the end of the Ruhr Authority. For German Chancellor Adenauer, the initiative offered an excellent opportunity to make West Germany internationally visible again.

European Political Cooperation

“The EC countries set up the European Political Cooperation (EPC) to better represent their foreign policy interests.”

EPC was the framework for foreign policy coordination between the EC Member States from 1970 to 1993. As an intergovernmental instrument, it served to coordinate common positions before it was transferred to the EU's more binding Common Foreign and Security Policy (CFSP) by the Treaty of Maastricht in 1993.

Greenland

“Greenland withdraws from the EU after a Referendum and decides to remain associated with the EU.”

Greenland was part of the EU from 1973 to 1985. After a referendum Greenland withdrew its participation, but remained associated with the EU as an Overseas Country and Territory (OCT).

Greenland is autonomous and belongs politically to Denmark, but not to the EU or the Schengen Area. As nationals of the Kingdom of Denmark, Greenlanders are nevertheless EU citizens and enjoy full EU citizenship rights, e.g. freedom of travel.

Europe's Flag and Anthem

“The **European flag** is hoisted for the first time and the song "Ode to Joy" becomes **the European anthem.**”

There is a prehistory of flag and anthem.

The European flag was largely designed by the French illustrator and employee of the Council of Europe, Arsène Heitz. In 1955, he submitted a design with twelve gold stars on a blue background. The 12 stars stand for unity, solidarity and harmony between the peoples of Europe. The number 12 was chosen because other numbers (13, 14, 15) were politically controversial.

From 1955, the flag was flown by the Council of Europe and in 1986 it was declared the official flag of the European Union.

In 1972, the Council of Europe declared the song "Ode to Joy" to be the European anthem. In 1986 it was adopted by EU leaders as the official anthem of the European Union. The anthem has no lyrics (as not to disadvantage any national language), it consists of music only. In the universal language of music, this anthem expresses the European ideals of freedom, peace and solidarity.

The European anthem is not intended to replace the national anthems of the EU countries but rather to celebrate the values they share. The anthem is played at official ceremonies involving the European Union and generally at all sorts of events with a European character.

Erasmus

“The Erasmus programme is launched.”

Desiderius Erasmus of Rotterdam (1466/1467/1469 to 1536) was a Dutch polymath. He is the most important representative of European humanism, the best-known Renaissance humanist and was an influential church reformer.

Erasmus+ is the central EU programme which provides grants for a wide range of activities in education, training, youth and sport. With a budget of approximately 26.2 billion euros (2021-2027), it enables millions of people, especially students and trainees, to spend a period abroad to increase their skills and employability.

Stays abroad for seniors in the field of adult education are also subsidised. There is no set age limit. Seniors can take part in transnational partnership programs in order to learn about other cultures and to share innovative practices.

The objective is lifelong learning, often realized through projects set up by educational institutions and digital participation.

Single European Act (Treaty of Luxembourg)

“Entry into force of the Single European Act (SEA) with the aim of completing the internal market on 1st January 1993.”

The SEA was the first special Reform Treaty, which was later followed by the Treaties of Maastricht, Amsterdam, Nice and Lisbon. It marked the provisional conclusion of a reform debate that had lasted several years.

The SEA (also: "Treaty of Luxembourg") is intended to gradually implement the internal market as an "area without internal borders"

- for the free movement of goods, persons, services and capital
- through changes in the functioning and decision-making procedures of the EU institutions
- by extending the competences of the European Economic Community (EEC) to the fields of research and development, the environment, transport, social policy, labour rights policy and equality
- through the introduction of "European Political Cooperation" (EPC) on the common foreign policy.

EU Ecolabel



“The EU Ecolabel - often referred to as the "Euroflower" - becomes the official ecolabel of the European Union. The label has already been in use since 1992.”

It certifies products and services that

- meet strict environmental standards throughout their entire life cycle,
- cause less waste, CO₂ emissions and hazardous chemicals,
- are more resource-efficient than comparable alternatives.

It is recognised in all EU member states as well as Norway, Liechtenstein and Iceland.

Companies apply for the label voluntarily to prove their environmental friendliness.

Product groups and certification:

The spectrum ranges from detergents, textiles and shoes to paints, electrical appliances and tourism services (campsites). Today about 77,000 products bear the label.

Food, beverages, pharmaceuticals and medical devices are currently exempt from labeling.

Difference to the Blue Angel:

While the Blue Angel is a national German seal, the EU Ecolabel is the European counterpart. However, both can often be found in parallel on products.

EUROPOL - European Union Agency for Law Enforcement Cooperation

“Founding of EUROPOL (European Police Office), based in The Hague. It is the EU's central coordinating body in the fight against large-scale crime and terrorism.”

EUROPOL was founded in 1998 and has been fully operational since 1999. EUROPOL supports EU enforcement agencies in fighting large-scale criminal activities such as terrorism, fraud and drug trafficking.

EUROPOL is based on the cooperation between EU Member States to fight more efficiently complex cross-border forms of crime.

It supports the 27 EU Member States through information exchange, intelligence, analysis and coordination of cross-border operations.

Europol is not a European police force with its own investigators on the ground, it does not carry out its own operational arrests, but it is a central hub for the exchange of information between national police authorities.

Focus: Combating drug trafficking, human trafficking, money laundering, cybercrime and terrorism.

EURO - Virtual Currency Unit

“Introduction of a common currency (EURO) in the EU. First as a virtual currency unit that replaces the ECU.”

The European Currency Unit (ECU) was the main instrument for preparing for the monetary union. The value of the ECU served as the basis for the introduction of the euro. Since 1979 it had been the unit of account of the European Monetary System (EMS). It was virtual book money. The ECU was a 'basket of currencies' made up of the currencies of the EU Member States.

On 1 January 1999, the euro was introduced as official currency unit in eleven member states of the European Union. Initially it was a purely virtual currency unit (book money) that only existed on electronic accounts. It was used for cashless payments, transfers, securities, and accounting purposes.

The aim was to create a stable, common European currency and to prepare for the introduction of physical euro cash.

The participating countries were Austria, Belgium, Finland, France, Germany, Ireland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Portugal and Spain. The conversion rates of the national currencies to the euro have been irrevocably fixed.

This phase lasted three years until the introduction of euro cash on 1 January 2002.

Charter of Fundamental Rights

“The Charter of Fundamental Rights of the European Union is adopted.”

On 8 December 2000 the Charter was adopted at the European Council in Nice. It represents an important milestone on the road to the legitimacy of the EU. With the Treaty of Lisbon in 2009, the Charter became legally binding on all member states (except Poland and the UK).

The **54 articles are divided into 7 titles** :

- **Dignity:** Human dignity, right to life, prohibition of torture/slavery.
- **Freedoms:** freedom of expression, data protection, freedom of assembly.
- **Equality:** non-discrimination, equal treatment of men and women.
- **Citizen's rights:** working conditions, prohibition of child labour.
- **Civil rights:** right to vote, right to good administration.
- **Justice:** Right to an effective remedy and to a fair trial.
- **General provisions governing the interpretation and application of the Charter**

These 7 titles also include social rights such as the protection of personal data, the right to marry and start a family, and the right to access education.

The Charter stands alongside national fundamental rights (such as the German Basic Law) and is actively applied by courts in the implementation of EU law. The Charter is interpreted by the European Court of Justice (CJEU) in order to protect fundamental rights uniformly throughout the Union.

EU Motto - United in Diversity

“The Commission chooses "United in Diversity" as the motto for the EU.”

The official motto of the European Union is "United in diversity" (Latin: *In varietate concordia*). It has been in use since 2000.

This motto emphasises that Europeans work together for peace and prosperity while preserving the continent's diverse cultures, languages and traditions.

It differs from the American motto "One out of many" (Latin: *E pluribus unum*), as, above all, the diversity of peoples in Europe is to be preserved.

In 2000 the motto of the European Union was created as part of a competition in which about 80,000 young people between the ages of 10 and 20 from the then 15 member states of the EU took part.

Core aspects:

- **Aim:** to create peace and prosperity through cooperation in a common European home, without giving up one's own identity
- **Diversity:** The EU consists of many different nations, languages (approx. 225 indigenous languages) and cultures. These differences are not understood as separation, but as enrichment.
- **Unity:** Despite the diversity, people belong together (unique political framework). Unity is based on common values such as democracy, solidarity and respect.

AGE Platform Europe - the European Umbrella Organisation of Senior Citizens' Organisations

“The platform is founded to represent the interests of elder people in the European Union.”

AGE Platform Europe is the largest European network of organisations by and for elder people. The aim is to make the diverse experiences and aspirations of the EU's growing older population heard and to raise awareness of the challenges of ageing.

The association is made up of organisations of elder people or those directly representing older people, as well as non-profit organisations that provide services to senior citizens or are active in the field of ageing. They have to be based in Europe.

The association participates in discussions relevant to senior citizens' policy at EU level and offers a platform for exchange between senior citizens' organisations from many European countries.

The office of AGE (based in Brussels) coordinates various EU projects.

Since 2005 the German Federal Association of Senior Citizens' Organisations (BAGSO) has been a member of AGE, the European umbrella organisation.

Treaty of Nice

“The Treaty of Nice strengthens the European Parliament. Institutional reforms are set in motion.”

The aim was to prepare for the then imminent eastward and southern enlargement without losing its decision-making capacity.

Behind this is the idea of European integration, i.e. the striving of the European states for more economic, political and social interdependence with each other.

The most important objective is to transfer tasks - such as climate or security policy - which are no longer or only with great difficulty for individual states to master, to institutions that go beyond the national level.

Treaty of Lisbon

“The structure and working methods of the EU are being reformed. (Further development of the Maastricht Treaty) The Treaty of Lisbon is the current contractual basis of the EU.”

The Treaty of Lisbon reformed the structures of the EU in order to make them more capable of acting, more democratic and more transparent after the eastward enlargement. The Treaty of Lisbon strengthened the European Parliament's participation, introduced "double majority" in votes and created the Office of an EU High Representative for Foreign Affairs.

The Parliament was given significantly more co-determination rights in legislation and is now on an equal footing with the Council of the European Union (representing the governments of the individual member states) in most policy areas.

EU citizens were given the right to participate in legislation with the "European Citizens' Initiative".

For the first time the treaty gave member states the explicit legal right (Article 50) to leave the EU, and established a procedure by which to do so.

Euro Sovereign Debt Crisis

“High national debt and falling tax revenues are leading to a slump in the economy in some EU countries; some countries are threatened with national bankruptcy.”

The financial crisis that originated in the USA (from 2007/2008) had a profound impact on the European Union (EU) and was the trigger for the subsequent euro sovereign debt crisis. It led to a serious banking crisis with an accompanying recession, rising unemployment and a loss of confidence in the financial system.

In Greece in particular, government debt rose due to falling economic output, growing unemployment figures and increased costs.

Other EU countries (Ireland, Portugal, Spain, Cyprus) followed into the crisis.

In order to prevent such crises in the future, structural changes have taken place in the EU. Among others the following measures were introduced:

- central banking supervision by the European Central Bank
- uniform rules for all large banks in the euro zone
- Rescue funds such as the European Stability Mechanism
- the principle of "bail-in" (owners and creditors are liable first, not the taxpayer)
- Stricter rules for national budgets (Stability and Growth Pact)

EU Recovery Package

“Several EU member states that are financially threatened with national bankruptcy must be supported by measures and instruments from the Euro Rescue Package.”

“Euro Recovery Package” is a collective term for measures and instruments of the European Union and the member states of the eurozone that are intended to ensure the solvency of vulnerable member states.

During the euro crisis, there was initially a temporary financial stability package established (EFSF = European Financial Stability Facility), which had to be used by several member states.

As early as 2010, the countries of the eurozone had reacted to the acute crisis with emergency instruments and various credit lines; thus they ensured that a bankruptcy of Greece could be averted.

Until 2012 more countries such as Ireland, Portugal, Spain and Cyprus had to apply for funds from the rescue package in order to stabilize their economy.

Since then permanent reforms have been made to the ESM (European Stability Mechanism) In order to be better prepared for future financial crisis and to be able to react more quickly.

Nobel Peace Prize

“The Nobel Peace Prize is awarded to the European Union (EU) "for over six decades contributed to the advancement of peace and reconciliation, democracy and human rights in Europe".

The Norwegian Nobel Committee honored the transformation of Europe from a continent of war to a continent of peace.

The EU topped up the approximately 930,000 euros in prize money to two million euros and donated the entire amount to educational projects for children in conflict zones.

Peak of the Refugee Crisis

“In a short time, more than a million people come to Europe, many of them fleeing war, violence or poverty. The countries with EU's external borders are overstrained. The Dublin Procedure only works to a limited extent.”

Triggered by the civil war in Syria, the IS in Iraq and the Taliban in Afghanistan, more than one million refugees reached Greece via Turkey.

The Dublin Procedure determines the EU country responsible for processing an asylum application, usually the first country where the asylum seeker entered the EU. The aim is to prevent asylum seekers from submitting multiple applications in different countries.

At no time the EU succeeded in agreeing on a solidarity-based distribution of refugees according to the Dublin Procedure (a redistribution according to fixed quotas to all member states) and enforcing the obligation to accept asylum seekers in all member states.

In order to maintain control over immigration and to restrict access to asylum, the EU member states decided on measures to tighten asylum and border control policies.

From 2016, the entry procedures at the EU's external borders were standardised. Before a migrant is allowed to enter the EU, he must submit to a stricter "preliminary check".

On 18 March 2016, an agreement was reached with Turkey to stop illegal immigration of refugees into the EU in exchange for a payment of 6 billion euros.

Brexit - Withdrawal of the United Kingdom from the EU

“In 2016, a referendum in the United Kingdom leads to the UK's withdrawal from the EU after several years of negotiations. - The EU has only 27 members.”

In 2016, 51.9% of the citizens of the United Kingdom (Great Britain and Northern Ireland) voted to leave the EU in a referendum on the UK's continued membership of the EU (leave 51.9% / remain 48.1%).

On 29.03.2017, the then Prime Minister Theresa May officially requested the withdrawal of the UK by writing to the European Council chaired by Donald Tusk, thus activating the legal mechanism for leaving the EU under Article 50.

The exit negotiations between the UK and the EU dragged on until 2020. During this period, the conditions for the withdrawal were regulated (e.g. finances, customs, product standards, transition period).

01.02.2020: UK leaves the EU, but continues to participate in the single market and customs union during a transition period until the end of 2020.

01.01.2021 Entry into force of the Trade and Cooperation Agreement.

Corona (Covid) Pandemic

“The health systems in the EU countries are overburdened and the economy and social life are in crisis due to numerous lockdown phases.”

EU fiscal rules have been used as flexibly as possible to help member states support health systems and businesses and preserve jobs.

EU state aid rules were relaxed so that member states could access low-cost loans to maintain the liquidity of the economy.

The "Next Generation EU" recovery plan with a budget of 750 billion euros to combat the economic impact of the coronavirus pandemic has been adopted.